

Formal Ordination Rejection

doc-formal-ordination-rejection

Leadership & Polity · Ordination · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Formal ordination as conferral of sacerdotal status or unique ministerial grace is rejected; recognition of elders/deacons by the local assembly with prayer and laying on of hands is biblical, but creates no clergy class.

In plain language

The proposition has two parts, and the words treat them differently. The first part denies that appointing leaders hands over a priestly status. On this the text is strong. The verbs of appointing are ordinary functional words. 'To designate by a show of hands' (cheirotoneo), used in Acts 14:23 and 2 Corinthians 8:19, means to designate someone by raising the hand, as in a show of hands in an assembly. 'To set in order or appoint' (kathistemi) in Titus 1:5 means to set someone in order over a task. 'To set apart for a task' (aphorizo) in Acts 13:2 means to set apart for a work, and there the Holy Spirit takes the initiative. None of these carries any priestly transfer. More tellingly, the priest word group, 'priest' (hiereus) and the noun for priesthood, 'priesthood' (hierateuma), is in the New Testament used for Israel's priests, for pagan priests, for Christ in Hebrews, and in 1 Peter 2:5 and 2:9 for all believers together, a royal priesthood, but it is never attached to an appointed elder, overseer, or deacon. So no separate priest class is named in the words. The laying on of hands also points away from a special rite, since across the canon that gesture is used mostly for healing and blessing, as in Matthew 9, Mark 5, and Luke 4, and only a few times for commissioning, always with prayer and fasting. The second part of the proposition is harder. It says ordination confers no unique ministerial grace. Here a real gift, a 'gift of grace' (charisma), is connected to the laying on of hands in the letters to Timothy. The difficulty is internal to the words. In 1 Timothy 4:14 the gift comes 'through' (dia) prophecy, with the hands only accompanying, 'with' (meta). In 2 Timothy 1:6 the same gift comes 'through' (dia) the laying on of Paul's hands directly. The two statements place the key preposition on different things and never say which is the true means, so the words leave open whether the rite conveyed the gift or merely accompanied it. That single unresolved point is why this lands as contested rather than settled.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0873	ἀφορίζω	aphorizo	to separate	10
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	
G1936	ἐπίθεσις	epithesis	laying on	4
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithemi	to put/lay on	39
G2406	ἱεράτευμα	hierateuma	priesthood	2
G2409	ἱερεύς	hiereus	priest	32

G2525	καθίστημι	kathistemi	to appoint/conduct	22
G3522	νηστεύω	nesteuo	to fast	21
G4244	πρεσβυτέριον	presbyterion	council of elders	3
G4291	προΐστημι	proistemi	to set before	8
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	86
G5486	χάρισμα	charisma	gift	17
G5495	χείρ	cheir	hand	179
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneo	to appoint	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two halves of the proposition land differently. The sacerdotal half (the claim that appointment does not transfer priestly status) is strongly supported, because the priest word group, namely 'priest' (hiereus) and 'priesthood' (hierateuma), is never applied in the New Testament to an appointed elder (presbyteros), overseer (episkopos), or servant-minister (diakonos), and 'priesthood' (hierateuma) in 1 Peter 2:5 and 2:9 is applied to all believers, so no separate priestly order is lexically attached to the appointment vocabulary. The appointment verbs themselves are functional: 'to designate by raising the hand in an assembly' (cheirotoneo) means to designate by raising the hand in an assembly, 'to set in order or appoint' (kathistemi) means to set in order or appoint, 'to set apart for a task' (aphorizo) means to set apart for a task, and none carries any priestly transfer. The unique remaining tension is the gift language. 1 Timothy 4:14 routes 'through' (dia) onto prophecy and makes the laying on of hands 'with, accompanying' (meta), accompanying, while 2 Timothy 1:6 routes 'through' (dia) onto the laying on of hands directly, and the two parallel statements do not rank which is the instrument that conveyed the 'gift of grace' (charisma). Because the words leave open whether the rite is instrumental cause or attendant sign of a conferred grace, the proposition's sub-clause about unique ministerial grace is contested, hence disputed rather than a clean affirmation.

Scripture

Acts.14.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G4336 προσεύχομαι, G3522 νηστεύω

Reasoning. The aorist (a completed past action) participle 'having designated by a show of hands' (cheirotoneo) governs appointing elders in each assembly, 'in every assembly' (kat ekklesian). The verb's stem sense, attested in the lexicon, is to designate or appoint by stretching out the hand, originally a show of hands in the Athenian 'assembly' (ekklesia), and it carries no priestly transfer or sacramental conferral semantics. The act is framed with 'to pray' (proseuchomai) prayer and 'to fast' (nesteuo) fasting and commendation to the Lord, presenting recognition rather than the granting of a priestly order.

2Cor.8.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Here 'to designate by raising the hand in an assembly' (cheirotoneo) describes a brother 'having been designated by a show of hands' (cheirotoneo) by the churches to travel with the collection. This is the only other genuine New Testament use of the verb, and the lexicon glosses it as appointment by vote of the assembly (ekklesia). It anchors the word's plain sense as congregational designation of a person for a task, with no priestly or sacerdotal content whatever, confirming the reading of Acts 14:23.

Acts.13.2 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0873 ἀφορίζω, G3522 νηστεύω

Reasoning. The Holy Spirit directs 'set apart' (aphorise), set apart, for the work to which Barnabas and Saul were already called, while the assembly was serving the Lord and 'fasting' (nesteuo, fasting). The lexicon gives 'to set apart for a task' (aphorizo) the sense to set apart and devote to a special purpose. The setting apart names a function or task, not the conferral of an enduring priestly status, and the initiative is the Spirit's rather than a rite performed by men.

Acts.13.3 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιτίθημι, G5495 χεῖρ, G4336 προσεύχομαι

Reasoning. Having fasted and prayed (from 'to pray', proseuchomai), they laid hands, 'having laid on the hands' (epithentes tas cheiras), on Barnabas and Saul and released them. Across the canon the idiom 'to lay upon' (epitithemi) plus 'hand' (cheir) occurs in twenty one verses and most often denotes healing touch or blessing, as in Matthew 9:18, Mark 5:23, Mark 6:5, Luke 4:40, and Luke 13:13, with Spirit impartation in Acts 8:17 and 19:6. Only Acts 6:6, here, and 1 Timothy 5:22 apply it to commissioning. The dominant canonical (spread across the whole Bible) sense is therefore contact for blessing, not a priestly investiture, so here the gesture reads as commendation for a journey of service.

1Tim.5.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιτίθημι, G5495 χεῖρ

Reasoning. Lay hands, 'lay hands' (cheiras epitithe), on no one hastily. The warning treats the laying on of hands as a deliberate human act that can be done rashly and that implicates the one performing it in others' sins. This presupposes a considered recognition of a person rather than an automatic sacramental channel that operates 'ex opere' (Latin for 'from the work itself', meaning automatically by the rite), which supports reading the appointment act as discerning recognition.

1Pet.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2406 ἱεράτευμα

Reasoning. Believers collectively are called a royal priesthood, 'royal priesthood' (basileion hierateuma), and in 1 Peter 2:5 a holy priesthood. The priest word group, 'priest' (hierous) and its cognate 'priesthood' (hierateuma), is in the New Testament applied to Israel's priests, to pagan priests, to Christ in the Melchizedek argument of Hebrews, and to the whole body of believers, but never to an appointed elder (presbyteros), overseer (episkopos), or servant-minister (diakonos). The absence of sacerdotal vocabulary attached to church appointees, together with its application to all believers, supports the proposition that recognition of leaders creates no separate clergy class.

1Tim.4.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5486 χάρισμα, G1936 ἐπίθεσις, G4244 πρεσβυτέριον

Reasoning. Timothy is told not to neglect the 'gift of grace' (charisma) in him, given 'through prophecy with the laying on of the hands of the council of elders' (dia propheteias meta epitheseos ton cheiron tou presbyteriou). Token tagging confirms 'through' (dia), Strong's G1223, governs prophecy, while 'with, accompanying' (meta), Strong's G3326, governs the laying on of the hands of the 'council of elders' (presbyterion). So prophecy is the channel and the hands are the accompanying act, and the agent named is the corporate council of elders, not a single ordaining priest. This wording leaves the rite as accompaniment to a Spirit given gift rather than its instrumental cause.

2Tim.1.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5486 χάρισμα, G1936 ἐπίθεσις, G5495 χεῖρ

Reasoning. Paul urges Timothy to rekindle the 'gift of grace of God' (charisma tou theou), the gift of God, which is in him 'through the laying on of my hands' (dia tes epitheseos ton cheiron mou). Token tagging confirms 'through' (dia), Strong's G1223, here governs the laying on of Paul's hands directly, a stronger instrumental phrasing than 1 Timothy 4:14, and this is the principal lexical datum a conferral reading leans on. Yet the gift is explicitly 'of God' (tou theou), of God, and is a 'gift of grace' (charisma) to be rekindled, 'to rekindle' (anazopurein), not described as an indelible priestly character. The two parallel statements route 'through' (dia) differently and do not rank which is the true instrument.

Titus.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι

Reasoning. Titus is to appoint elders in every town, 'you may appoint elders in every city' (katasteses presbyterous kata polin). The lexicon gives 'to set in order or appoint' (kathistemi) the sense to set in order, appoint, make, or constitute, the same verb used for setting stewards and officials over duties. The verb denotes functional placement into a recognized role, with no priestly transfer or sacramental sense, reinforcing that appointment is to a task of oversight rather than into a sacerdotal order.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.13.2	Acts.6.4	tsk	1
Acts.13.2	Acts.22.21	tsk	1
2Tim.1.6	2Tim.4.2	tsk	1
1Tim.5.22	1Tim.3.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Tim.1.6 · addressed

The phrase 'through the laying on of my hands' (dia tes epitheseos ton cheiron mou) uses 'through' (dia) with the laying on of hands, which on its own can read as instrumental cause and so could support a conferral view. It is addressed by reading it alongside 1 Timothy 4:14, where token tagging shows 'through' (dia) governs prophecy and the laying on of hands is governed by 'with, accompanying' (meta), accompanying. The same gift is described with the preposition attached to different elements in the two letters, and the gift is called 'of God' (tou theou), of God. The texts therefore present God as the source acting through prophecy, with the imposition of hands as the attendant act in one statement and as a means in the other, so the lexical data neither compel nor exclude an instrumental conferral, leaving this sub-point genuinely open.

1Tim.4.14 · addressed

The presence of 'council of elders' (presbyterion), a council of elders performing the laying on of hands, shows a corporate recognition act by the assembly's elders rather than a transfer through a single ordaining priest. The construction keeps prophecy as the 'through' (dia) channel and the imposition as a 'with, accompanying' (meta) accompaniment, which is consistent with recognition that confers function without establishing a separate sacerdotal order. It complicates only the narrow question of whether a gift is conveyed by the rite, not the broader question of priestly status.

Acts.8.18 · addressed

The noun 'laying on' (epithesis) appears here for the laying on of the apostles' hands through which the Spirit was given, which Simon tried to buy. This shows the same noun used outside any elder appointment, for Spirit impartation, and it is not resolved as supporting ordination because it concerns an apostolic act of conveying the Spirit, not the constituting of a clergy office. It confirms that 'laying on' (epithesis) is a general gesture word, not a technical term for sacerdotal ordination.

Concordance traversed

G5500, G1936, G2007, G5495, G5486, G2525, G0873, G4244, G4291, G2409, G2406, G4336, G3522, G1577

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts and the Pastoral Epistles fall outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a textual-criticism tool) was not consulted. The marked variants in the SBLGNT apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) for Acts 13:1-3 and 14:23 concern word order and minor particles and do not touch 'to designate by raising the hand in an assembly' (cheirotoneo), 'laying on' (epithesis), 'gift of grace' (charisma), or the prepositions 'through' (dia) and 'with, accompanying' (meta) in 1 Timothy 4:14 and 2 Timothy 1:6, so the verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sacramental_ordination, congregational_recognition

analogia scripturae invoked

sacramental_ordination: false · On this reading 'through the laying on of my hands' (dia tes epitheseos ton cheiron mou) in 2 Timothy 1:6 is taken as instrumental, the laying on of hands being the means through which the 'gift of grace' (charisma) was conveyed, and the gift is then understood as a permanent ministerial grace tied to the office. The strongest lexical support is that 2 Timothy 1:6 does place 'through' (dia) directly on the laying on of hands, and that 'laying on of hands' (epithesis cheiron) recurs as a fixed expression. On this lens the proposition's denial of a conferred unique ministerial grace would be too strong.

congregational_recognition: true · On this reading 'to designate by raising the hand in an assembly' (cheirotoneo) and 'to set in order or appoint' (kathistemi) are plain appointment verbs, 'to set apart for a task' (aphorizo) is task-setting at the Spirit's initiative, the laying on of hands is the canon's general gesture of blessing and commendation, prayer and fasting frame the act, the gift in 1 Timothy 4:14 comes 'through' (dia) prophecy with the hands only 'with, accompanying' (meta) accompanying, and the priest word group is never applied to appointed leaders but to all believers in 1 Peter 2:9. This yields recognition of function with no sacerdotal order, affirming the proposition.

The proposition is a compound. Its sacerdotal-status clause is well supported lexically because no priest vocabulary attaches to appointees and 'priesthood' (hierateuma) is applied to all believers. Its unique-ministerial-grace clause turns on whether 'through' (dia) plus 'laying on' (epithesis) in 2 Timothy 1:6 is instrumental cause or attendant means, a point on which 1 Timothy 4:14 and 2 Timothy 1:6 route the preposition differently and do not rank. That single underdetermination is why the verdict is disputed rather than a clean affirmation.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the New Testament vocabulary for appointing elders and deacons ('to designate by raising the hand in an assembly' (cheirotoneo), 'to set in order or appoint' (kathistemi), 'to set apart for a task' (aphorizo), 'laying on of hands' (epithesis cheiron), 'gift of grace' (charisma)) describes a transfer of priestly status or unique ministerial grace, or a corporate recognition of function with prayer and laying on of hands, and

whether any sacerdotal or priest vocabulary is attached to such appointees.

The original stem encodes a verdict by asserting that formal ordination as sacerdotal conferral is rejected and that recognition creates no clergy class. This is a Brethren-distinctive framing. The verdict was derived against the neutralized form. The result is disputed because the sacerdotal-status half is lexically well supported, but the unique-ministerial-grace half rests on a genuinely underdetermined construction, the differing placement of 'through' (dia) in 1 Timothy 4:14 and 2 Timothy 1:6.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5500
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1936
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2525
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0873
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5486
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.14
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.1.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.14.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.13.2
variant	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Acts.14.23

License audit

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Reason. SBLGNT-text is under the SBLGNT-EULA (redistribute=false), so the aggregate evidence bundle is not safe to redistribute in bulk, even though the lexical and morphology sources used (STEPBible-TBESG, STEPBible-TAGNT, MorphGNT-morphology, TSK) are each individually redistributable.

Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent